FREE GUIDE · US

The 7-Day $5 Dinner Plan

A free budget meal plan for 1–2 people. Seven dinners, one shopping list, one price worksheet.

All prices in this guide are goals or EXAMPLE numbers, not real store prices. Prices change by store, city and week. Your cost may be lower or higher. This is general information, not medical or nutrition advice.

How this plan works

The idea is simple: **a dinner that costs about $5 or less for 1–2 servings** is possible when you build it on cheap staples and cook some things twice.

1. **Pick 3 cheap proteins** (eggs, dry or canned beans, chicken thighs or canned tuna).
2. **Pick 3 cheap carbs** (rice, pasta, potatoes).
3. **Add frozen or in-season vegetables.**
4. **Cook once, eat twice.** Make a bigger pot on Monday and use the leftovers for lunch.

Your goal: about $5 per dinner. That is a target, not a promise. Use the price worksheet on the last page to check your real total at your own store.

The 7 dinners

Mon: Chicken, rice and frozen veg
Bake 2 lb chicken thighs (425°F / 220°C, 35–40 min, until 165°F / 74°C inside). Serve half with rice and steamed frozen vegetables. Save the other half for Wednesday and Thursday.

Tue: Bean and rice bowl
Simmer canned or soaked black beans with onion, garlic powder, cumin and salt. Serve over rice. Top with a fried egg if you want more protein.

Wed: Chicken fried rice
Chop leftover chicken. Fry cold rice in a little oil with a scrambled egg, frozen peas and carrots, and soy sauce. Cold rice works better than fresh rice.

Thu: Chicken and veg soup
Simmer leftover chicken with onion, carrots, a spoon of rice or a handful of pasta, salt and pepper in 6 cups of water. Makes extra for tomorrow's lunch.

Fri: Tuna (or egg) pasta
Boil pasta. Stir in canned tuna (or 3–4 chopped hard-

boiled eggs), a spoon of oil or butter, black pepper and a handful of frozen peas. Add lemon juice if you have it.

Sat: Potato and egg skillet
Dice potatoes small and pan-fry in oil with onion until crisp (about 15 minutes, covered for the first 7). Crack 2–3 eggs on top, cover, and cook until set.

Sun: Clean-out-the-fridge bowl
Use up leftovers. Rice or pasta as a base, then any beans, eggs or vegetables left over. Add a spoon of salsa or tomato sauce. Then plan next week's list.

Your shopping list (one trip)

Protein

- 1 dozen eggs
- 2 lb chicken thighs or drumsticks
- 2 cans black beans (or 1 lb dry)
- 1 can tuna (or extra eggs)

Carbs

- 2 lb rice
- 1 lb pasta
- 5 lb potatoes

Vegetables

- 1 bag frozen mixed vegetables
- 1 bag frozen peas
- 1 small bag carrots
- 3 onions

Basics (skip what you already have)

- Cooking oil, salt, pepper, garlic powder, cumin, soy sauce

Rough cost: this depends on your store. Fill in the worksheet below with your real prices.

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6 ways to keep each dinner near $5

1. **Check the unit price** (price per ounce or per pound) on the shelf tag, not the big price.
2. **Buy store brand** for basics like rice, pasta, beans and frozen vegetables. Compare the unit price first.
3. **Buy whole chicken pieces**, not boneless breasts. Bone-in thighs and drumsticks are often cheaper per pound.
4. **Use frozen vegetables.** They are easy to portion and don't rot.
5. **Cook a double batch** of rice and beans. Rice keeps up to 4 days in the fridge.
6. **Use up leftovers first.** Throwing away food is throwing away money.

Food safety (important)

- Put cooked food in the fridge within 2 hours.
- Eat leftovers within 3–4 days. When in doubt, throw it out.
- Reheat leftovers until hot all the way through (165°F / 74°C).
- Cook chicken to 165°F (74°C).
- Cool cooked rice quickly and refrigerate it. Don't leave it out for hours.

Easy swaps

- **No chicken?** Use extra eggs and beans.
- **Vegetarian?** Replace chicken with beans, eggs and extra vegetables.
- **More people?** Double the rice, beans, pasta and potatoes first. They are the cheapest filling foods.
- **Allergy or health condition?** Change the foods to what is safe for you. Talk to a doctor or dietitian for medical needs.

Price worksheet (fill in at your store)

Item	Amount	My price (write it in)
Eggs	1 dozen	$
Chicken thighs	2 lb	$
Black beans	2 cans	$
Tuna	1 can	$
Rice	2 lb	$
Pasta	1 lb	$
Potatoes	5 lb	$
Frozen vegetables + peas	2 bags	$
Carrots + onions	1 bag + 3	$
Total		**$**

Divide the total by 7 dinners to see your cost per dinner. If it is higher than $5, swap in a cheaper protein, buy store brand, or use what is on sale this week.

Made for the community. If this helped you, share it with a friend who is watching their budget.